

Lesson 07:

Linear Coherence of a Passage: Al-Baqarah, Ali 'Imran, An-Naba, and An-Nahl

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The coherence between passages of the Quran can be seen through a steady progression of thoughts and imagery in Al-Baqarah (91-93), Ali 'Imran (64-67), An-Naba (6-16) and An-Nahl (64-69/78-81). Allah encourages us to reflect on the entire creation so we can be grateful and mindful of His countless blessings.

- The Quran doesn't have paragraphs, all the ayat are bunched together, the only units are suwar and ayat.
- Sometimes there are a group of ayat that talked about a subject, and then the next group of ayat is about another subject, for examples, a group of ayat can talk about the Pharaoh and the following group would describe the Creation of Allah.
- In the Quran we have: 100:1 - وَالْعَادِيَّاتِ صَبْحًا - 100:2 فَالْمُورِيَّاتِ قَدْحًا those are one distinct subject, that is what Ustadh Nouman calls a passage.
- Orientalists and other western academics use the word « section » (Ustadh Nouman used that in the past also), but for the purpose of our study we will use the word « passage » for a distinct set of ayat, which are more than an ayah and less than a surah.

There are two ways of studying a passage:

=> Progression:

How is an argument progressing from the first, to the second to the third...until the last ayah, leading to a conclusion (are they escalating, building up on an idea previously cited?)

Progression is more about developing an argument.

=>Structural view of passages:

It is more complicated and highly challenging since it is the process of taking a step back and looking at the structural view of certain passages.

Case Study #1: Al-Baqarah (91-93)

Theses ayat are part of the discourse on the Israelites where Allah is criticizing them.

وَإِذَا قِيلَ لَهُمْ آمِنُوا بِمَا أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ قَالُوا نُنُومُ بِمَا أَنْزَلَ عَلَيْنَا وَيَكْفُرُونَ بِمَا وَرَاءَهُ وَهُوَ الْحَقُّ مُصَدِّقًا لِمَا مَعَهُمْ ۚ قُلْ فَلِمَ تَقْتُلُونَ أَنْبِيَاءَ اللَّهِ مِنْ قَبْلُ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ ﴿٩١﴾ وَلَقَدْ جَاءَكُمْ مُوسَىٰ بِالْبَيِّنَاتِ ثُمَّ اتَّخَذْتُمُ الْعِجْلَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ وَأَنْتُمْ ظَالِمُونَ ﴿٩٢﴾

وَإِذْ أَخَذْنَا مِيثَاقَكُمْ وَرَفَعْنَا فَوْقَكُمْ الطُّورَ خُذُوا مَا آتَيْنَاكُمْ بِقُوَّةٍ وَاسْمَعُوا قَالُوا سَمِعْنَا وَعَصَيْنَا وَأَشْرَيْنَا فِي قُلُوبِهِمُ الْعِجْلَ بِكُفْرِهِمْ ۚ قُلْ بِئْسَمَا يَأْمُرُكُمْ بِهِ إِيمَانُكُمْ إِن كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ ﴿٩٣﴾

And when it is said to them, "Believe in what Allah has sent down" they say, "We already believe in what was sent to us." And they disbelieve in what came after it, while it is the truth confirming that which is with them. Say, "Then why did you engage in killing the prophets of Allah from so long ago, if in fact you are all believers?" (91) And Moses certainly came to you with the clear evidences. You held on to the calf [to worship] even after him, while you were doing wrong (92) When We took the covenant from you and raised the mount above you, [saying], « Hold on to what we have given you with great might and listen ». They said, "We hear and disobey." And thus, the love of the calf was instilled in their hearts because of their disbelief. Tell them, « How terrible this faith of yours tells you to do, if in fact you are believers." (93)

Connection

- The first issue brought was: when they are told accept the Quran, they say no, instead of having reverence to the Quran, they said they already have the Torah, so they won't believe in the Quran.
- And Allah says «No you don't, if you did, you would see that the Quran is confirming what truth you have left in the Torah ».
- And if you are were following the Torah, how can you kill the Prophets who taught the Torah. Allah proves that their killing of the Prophets means they don't believe in it as they claim, they actually justify the killing of the Prophets who came to reinforce the Torah.
- The Prophets of Bani Israel did not come with new revelations, rather they came to restore the Torah given to Musa (PBUH).
- So the argument progresses, and Allah says, «fine, you don't respect the Prophets, but at least respect the one who saved you from Pharaoh, you didn't even spare Musa (PBUH), you started worshipping the calf even in his presence.
- «And Musa came to you with the clear proofs, yet you still worship the calf».
- So now we have seen that they have no regard for the Torah, no regard for the teachers of the Torah, no regard for their political hero, their Prophet, the one they identified themselves with.
- But the argument is not done. Let's talk about how much regard you have for Allah Himself. So Allah says: إِذْ أَخَذْنَا مِيثَاقَكُمْ «We ourselves took the covenant from you», وَرَفَعْنَا فَوْقَكُمْ الطُّورَ «We raised the mountain above you», you even turn to God and say سَمِعْنَا وَعَصَيْنَا « We hear and we disobey ».
- The conversation started by نُوْمِنُ بِمَا أُنْزِلَ عَلَيْنَا «we believe on what was given on to us», by the end Allah says « what a terrible thing that faith of yours tells you to do: killing Prophets, disregarding Musa (PBUH), worshipping the calf, defying Allah directly»

- So we see how their smart answers have been crushed, one after the other, with a progression that gets worse and worse.

Case Study #2: Ali 'Imran (64-67)

يَا أَهْلَ الْكِتَابِ تَعَالَوْا إِلَى كَلِمَةٍ سَوَاءٍ بَيْنَنَا وَبَيْنَكُمْ أَلَّا نَعْبُدَ إِلَّا اللَّهَ وَلَا نُشْرِكَ بِهِ شَيْئًا وَلَا يَتَّخِذَ بَعْضُنَا بَعْضًا أَرْبَابًا مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ ۚ فَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَقُولُوا اشْهَدُوا بِأَنَّا مُسْلِمُونَ ﴿٦٤﴾ يَا أَهْلَ الْكِتَابِ لِمَ تُحَاجُّونَ فِي إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَمَا أُنْزِلَتِ التَّوْرَةُ وَالْإِنْجِيلُ إِلَّا مِنْ بَعْدِهِ ۚ أَفَلَا تَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٦٥﴾ هَآ أَنتُمْ هَؤُلَاءِ حَاجِّجُنَّ فِيمَا لَكُمْ بِهِ عِلْمٌ فَلِمَ تُحَاجُّونَ فِيمَا لَيْسَ لَكُمْ بِهِ عِلْمٌ ۚ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ وَأَنْتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ ﴿٦٦﴾ مَا كَانَ إِبْرَاهِيمُ يَهُودِيًّا وَلَا نَصْرَانِيًّا وَلَكِنْ كَانَ حَنِيفًا مُسْلِمًا وَمَا كَانَ مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ ﴿٦٧﴾

Translation:

Say, "People of the Book, come towards a word that is in common between you and ourselves, that we will not worship anyone except Allah and will not make any partners with Him and we will not take some of us as opposed to others as God besides Allah" And if they still turn away, then as they turn away say to them, «At least testify that we are Muslims" (64) O People of the Book, why are you even arguing about Ibrahim while the Torah and the Gospel were only revealed after him? Then will you not reason? (65) Here you are, debating about that of which you have [some] knowledge, but why do you argue about that of which you have no knowledge? And Allah knows, while you know not. (66) Abraham was neither a Jew nor a Christian, however he was one inclining toward truth, a Muslim [submitting to Allah]. And he was not of the polytheists. (67)

Connection

- In ayah 64, Muslims are told to give this invitation to Jewish and Christians تَعَالَوْا إِلَى كَلِمَةٍ سَوَاءٍ بَيْنَنَا وَبَيْنَكُمْ « come towards a word that is in common between you and ourselves».
- Some Christians' theological argument is that the salvation is only through the blood of Jesus, and the way to save yourself is to accept Jesus as your Lord and Savior. Then what about those that came before him, like Ibrahim (PBUH) and Musa (PBUH)? Will they enter Paradise without Jesus?
- Some people came up with this new theory: those Prophets and people that came before are stuck in an elevator called «purgatory», between Hell and Heaven. On Judgment Day, they will declare Jesus as their Lord and Savior and enter Paradise.
- They used to declare themselves being part of Ibrahim's (PBUH) legacy, but in ayah 66, Allah Himself refutes it. They also used to separate themselves from the Muslims saying « you are Muslim, we are not », so Allah says, « Ibrahim was neither Jew, nor Christian». That is to say, by calling us Muslim, you are counting us among those who are following the legacy of Ibrahim (PBUH). So you have given us the license to carry it. You don't get to say you are an Abrahamic faith now.
- That is how the argument has progressed, from Islam to Ibrahim (PBUH), thus, completely setting apart Jews and Christians from Ibrahim's legacy.

Case Study #3: An-Naba' (6-16)

أَلَمْ نَجْعَلِ الْأَرْضَ مِهَادًا ﴿٦﴾ وَالْجِبَالَ أَوْتَادًا ﴿٧﴾ وَخَلَقْنَاكُمْ أَزْوَاجًا ﴿٨﴾ وَجَعَلْنَا نَوْمَكُمْ سُبَاتًا ﴿٩﴾ وَجَعَلْنَا اللَّيْلَ لِبَاسًا ﴿١٠﴾ وَجَعَلْنَا النَّهَارَ مَعَاشًا ﴿١١﴾ وَبَنَيْنَا فَوْقَكُمْ سَبْعًا شِدَادًا ﴿١٢﴾ وَجَعَلْنَا سِرَاجًا وَهَّاجًا ﴿١٣﴾ وَأَنْزَلْنَا مِنَ الْمُعْصِرَاتِ مَاءً ثَجَّاجًا ﴿١٤﴾ لِنُخْرِجَ بِهِ حَبًّا وَنَبَاتًا ﴿١٥﴾ وَجَنَّاتٍ أَلْفَافًا ﴿١٦﴾

Translation:

Have We not made the earth a resting place? (6) And the mountains as stakes? (7) And We created you in pairs (8) And made your sleep [a means for] rest (9) And made the night as clothing (10) And made the day for livelihood (11) And constructed above you seven strong [heavens] (12) And made [therein] a burning lamp (13) And sent down, from the rain clouds, pouring water (14) That We may bring forth thereby grain and vegetation (15) And gardens of entwined growth. (16)

Connection

- Notice the imagery in these ayat. That surah deals mainly with the fact that there is a life after death, Judgment Day is coming.
- And everything Allah made is in pairs: Life/Death, Paradise/Hell, Earth (Flat land)/Mountain.
- Again, a lot of imagery: مِهَاد is a bed and it is also the womb of a mother, the earth is being described as having the same quality of a mother (the earth produces life, so is the mother), the mountain is the symbol of strength, stability, it is supposed to be the man's role (strong, stable). So the female and the male are compared to the earth and the mountain (described as أَوْتَاد). Men are called رِجَال, it comes from رَجَلَ, which means a foot (men have their feet stable on the ground).
- Neal Robinson beautifully said in his work on this Surah:

Think about all this imagery as somebody on a journey, traveling in the desert. The bed is the earth. He set up his tent as night comes. So the entire earth is a bed, and what is the tent? The mountain. Since everything is in pairs, the night comes and he is going to sleep next to his wife. The night is falling, and is described as a garment (لباس)

- The only other time in the Quran that spouses and لباس (garment, clothing) come together is concerning the ayah of Ramadan. هُنَّ لِبَاسٌ لَكُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ لِبَاسٌ لَهُنَّ «they are a clothing for you and you are a clothing for them» (2:187). The night has been made into a garment just like your spouse is your garment

He continues:

Then it's time to make a living, the intense burning sun rises, it can also be a kind of death, but Allah brings relief, water comes down from the sky, and then gardens are mentioned, life is sustained.

- Allah is saying that your life in this world is like one traveler in the desert. He goes, sleeps at night, puts his tent down, then he gets up and rolls up his tent; the destination would be a garden.
- So that is the progression of imagery in Surah An-Naba

Case Study #4: An-Nahl (64-69)

وَمَا أُنزِلْنَا عَلَيْكَ الْكِتَابَ إِلَّا لِتُبَيِّنَ لَهُمُ الَّذِي اخْتَلَفُوا فِيهِ ۖ وَهُدًى وَرَحْمَةً لِّقَوْمٍ يُؤْمِنُونَ ﴿٦٤﴾ وَاللَّهُ أَنْزَلَ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً فَأَخْيَا بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا ۚ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَةً لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٦٥﴾ وَإِنَّ لَكُمْ فِي الْأَنْعَامِ لَعِبْرَةً ۚ نُسْقِيكُمْ مِمَّا فِي بُطُونِهِ مِنْ بَيْنِ فَرْثٍ وَدَمٍ لَبَنًا خَالِصًا سَائِغًا لِلشَّارِبِينَ ﴿٦٦﴾ وَمِنْ ثَمَرَاتِ النَّخِيلِ وَالْأَعْنَابِ تَتَّخِذُونَ مِنْهُ سَكَرًا وَرِزْقًا حَسَنًا ۚ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَةً لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٦٧﴾ وَأَوْحَىٰ رَبُّكَ إِلَى النَّحْلِ أَنْ اتَّخِذِي مِنَ الْجِبَالِ بُيُوتًا وَمِنَ الشَّجَرِ وَمِمَّا يَعْرِشُونَ ﴿٦٨﴾ ثُمَّ كُلِي مِنْ كُلِّ الثَّمَرَاتِ ۚ فَاسْلُكِي سُبُلَ رَبِّكِ ذُلُلًا ۚ يَخْرُجُ مِنْ بُطُونِهَا شَرَابٌ مُخْتَلِفٌ أَلْوَانُهُ فِيهِ شِفَاءٌ لِّلنَّاسِ ۚ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَةً لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٦٩﴾

And We have not revealed to you the Book, [O Muhammad], except for you to make clear to them that wherein they have differed and as guidance and mercy for a people who believe. **(64)** And Allah has sent down rain from the sky and given life thereby to the earth after its lifelessness. Indeed in that is a sign for a people who listen. **(65)** And indeed, for you in grazing livestock is a lesson. We give you drink from what is in their bellies - between excretion and blood - pure milk, palatable to drinkers. **(66)** And from the fruits of the palm trees and grapevines you take intoxicant and good provision. Indeed in that is a sign for a people who reason. **(67)** And your Lord inspired to the bee, "Take for yourself among the mountains, houses, and among the trees and [in] that which they construct. **(68)** Then eat from all the fruits and follow the ways of your Lord laid down [for you]." There emerges from their bellies a drink, varying in colors, in which there is healing for people. Indeed in that is a sign for a people who give thought. **(69)**

Connection

- What connects these ayat is drinks: water from the sky, wine, juice, honey, it is a progressive passage.
- Ustadh Nouman deliberately places ayah 64 as the beginning of this passage. It is not about drinks at all, rather, it deals with revelation coming down so that we can benefit from it, and it is also a guidance and a mercy for people who seek to believe.
- Everything else following this is imagery that will further our understanding of revelation itself.
- So Allah said He sent water from the sky and gave life to the earth **اللَّهُ أَنْزَلَ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً فَأَخْيَا بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا**, just like revelation comes from the sky, and gives life to the heart.
- The water coming from the sky, is that a sign for the ears or for the eyes? It is for the eyes, however, if we look at the end of the ayah, it says: «In it there is a sign for people that listen», so we understand here that it is talking about revelation (water, we see it, and revelation we hear it). Here water is a metaphor.

- The earth can be brought to life, something good or not can come from it. So let's keep that in mind.
- The sahabah were in a terrible environment, surrounded by impurities. What is implied here is that purity can come out from a very impure environment.
- Another image here, even in the worst environment, revelation can come and reform it
- The next step: Allah wants us to ponder over the fruits that come from palm trees, grapes, and He says وَمِنْ ثَمَرَاتِ النَّخِيلِ وَالْأَعْنَابِ تَتَّخِذُونَ مِنْهُ سَكَرًا وَرِزْقًا حَسَنًا « good things come from it and bad things come from it».
- The people that were given revelation before us, the Israelites, received a lot of good: lots of Prophets, the Torah and they used that goodness incorrectly.
- It is not an accident that at the very end, Surah An-Nahl will criticize the Israelites.
- Allah revealed to the bee to take the pathway that Allah has commanded them to, just like the Angels who deliver revelation. The benefit of it contains different textures (ayat about wisdom, forgiveness, counsel, knowledge).
- In honey there is a healing for people. The only other time shifa is used in the Quran is when it refers to it. So Quran is shifa and honey is shifa too.
- The way honey is extracted is unique and it is only possible for bees to do it.
- We can go to the same flower that the bees went to but we can't produce the same things.
- The physical imagery in the Quran and how it progresses is a very profound spiritual experience.

Case Study #5: An-Nahl (78-81)

وَاللَّهُ أَخْرَجَكُمْ مِنْ بُطُونِ أُمَّهَاتِكُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ شَيْئًا وَجَعَلَ لَكُمُ السَّمْعَ وَالْأَبْصَارَ وَالْأَفْئِدَةَ ۚ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ ﴿٧٨﴾ أَلَمْ يَرْزُقُوا إِلَى الطَّيْرِ مُسَخَّرَاتٍ فِي جَوْ السَّمَاءِ مَا يُمَسِّكُهُنَّ إِلَّا اللَّهُ ۚ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يُؤْمِنُونَ ﴿٧٩﴾ وَاللَّهُ جَعَلَ لَكُمْ مِنْ بُيُوتِكُمْ سَكَنًا وَجَعَلَ لَكُمْ مِنْ جُلُودِ الْأَنْعَامِ بُيُوتًا تَسْتَخِفُّونَهَا يَوْمَ ظَعْنِكُمْ وَيَوْمَ إِقَامَتِكُمْ ۚ وَمِنْ أَصْوَابِهَا وَأَوْبَارِهَا وَأَشْعَارِهَا أَثَاءًا وَمَتَاعًا إِلَى حِينٍ ﴿٨٠﴾ وَاللَّهُ جَعَلَ لَكُمْ مِمَّا خَلَقَ ظِلَالًا وَجَعَلَ لَكُمْ مِنَ الْجِبَالِ أَكْنَانًا وَجَعَلَ لَكُمْ سَرَابِيلَ تَقِيكُمُ الْحَرَّ وَسَرَابِيلَ تَقِيكُمُ الْبَأْسَ ۚ كَذَلِكَ يُتِمُّ نِعْمَتَهُ عَلَيْكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُسْلِمُونَ ﴿٨١﴾

Translation:

And Allah has extracted you from the wombs of your mothers not knowing a thing, and He made for you hearing and vision and intellect that perhaps you would be grateful. (78) Do they not see the birds controlled in the atmosphere of the sky? None holds them up except Allah. Indeed in that are signs for a people who believe. (79) And Allah has made for you from your homes a place of rest and made for you from the hides of the animals tents which you find light on your day of travel and your day of encampment; and from their wool, fur and hair is furnishing and enjoyment for a time. (80) And Allah has made for you, from that which He has created, shadows and has made for you from the mountains, shelters and has made for you garments which protect you from the heat and garments which protect you from your [enemy in] battle. Thus does He complete His favor upon you that you might submit [to Him]. (81)

Connection

- It starts with اللَّهُ أَخْرَجَكُمْ مِّن بُطُونِ أُمَّهَاتِكُمْ, « you came out of the bellies of your mothers» whatever comes after the first part of the ayah, we should be grateful for (hearing, vision, intellect).
- What we hear from Allah should affect how we see things, and that should affect our hearts. It is a progressive relationship between hearing, seeing and our heart. How does it affect our heart? It makes us grateful.
- In the belly of our mother, we were surrounded by comfort, now that Allah has taken us out, we should observe how a bird is kept in the belly of the sky أَلَمْ يَرْوُا إِلَى الطَّيْرِ مُسَخَّرَاتٍ فِي جَوْ السَّمَاءِ. Nobody is holding them in place except Allah, just like a baby inside its mother's belly (seeing a bird should make us think about that).
- Even if we came out of the covering inside our mother's belly, Allah gave us a new covering: the comfort of our home where we should have sakan سَكَنَ (peace).
- The mountains contains cave for us to take refuge if needed.
- We also have the cover of our clothes, even during war.
- We are still inside some level of Rahma of Allah.
- However on Judgment Day, Allah says: «you have left behind whatever cover you had ».
- The theme of this passage is Allah keeping us covered in any type of situation.